

Last episode, I argued that more successful esports have emerged in the last five years than ever. This is a nice surprise to those of us who feel like we're waiting in vain for the "next VALORANT". But it did come with some caveats:

- That newer esports do not appear to be reliably hitting the production or audience scale of VAL or the Classic Titles (CS, LoL, etc)
- That newer esports tend to be in previously under-served markets, platforms or genres, rather than where there are already strong incumbents.
- That it seemed like once a title occupies a particular genre x platform x market "niche", competitors rarely (if ever) survive.

All of this led me to the conclusion that individual esports might be crowding each other out: directly competing for the same audience attention, such that ultimately the scene will consolidate around a few hardened, mature titles and new esports growth will become within-title only, rather than there being room for more, new esports.

Something something *big if true*.

So I decided the next thing I'd try to do is gather evidence to examine the hypothesis that, within a niche, say, tactical FPS on PC in Brazil, there really was a process of competitive exclusion and that a single title ended up being dominant. This is where things started to go awry.

## let's knock the wheels off this thing

I find a peculiar pleasure in tugging on a thread of thought and watching it unravel like a badly woven sweater vest. This is what happens: you begin with the question you *think* you're asking and you get to finding an answer, but the more you think about it, the more you start to realise that you're probably not asking your question in the right way. Or, alternatively, the solid ground you thought you were on with that question turns out to be wobbly as fuck. This is exhilarating - except that quite often you arrive at a resolution only to find you need to go a layer deeper, and deeper, and deeper you go. If you're very lucky, finally, you find the question you should have asked first all along.

Here is how it went: I hypothesised that within a niche {genre x platform x market}, one esports must ultimately dominate at the expense of others. So, in Brazil, ultimately Counter-Strike should crowd out VALORANT and Rainbow 6 Siege on PC, for example, to occupy the Tactical-FPS niche.

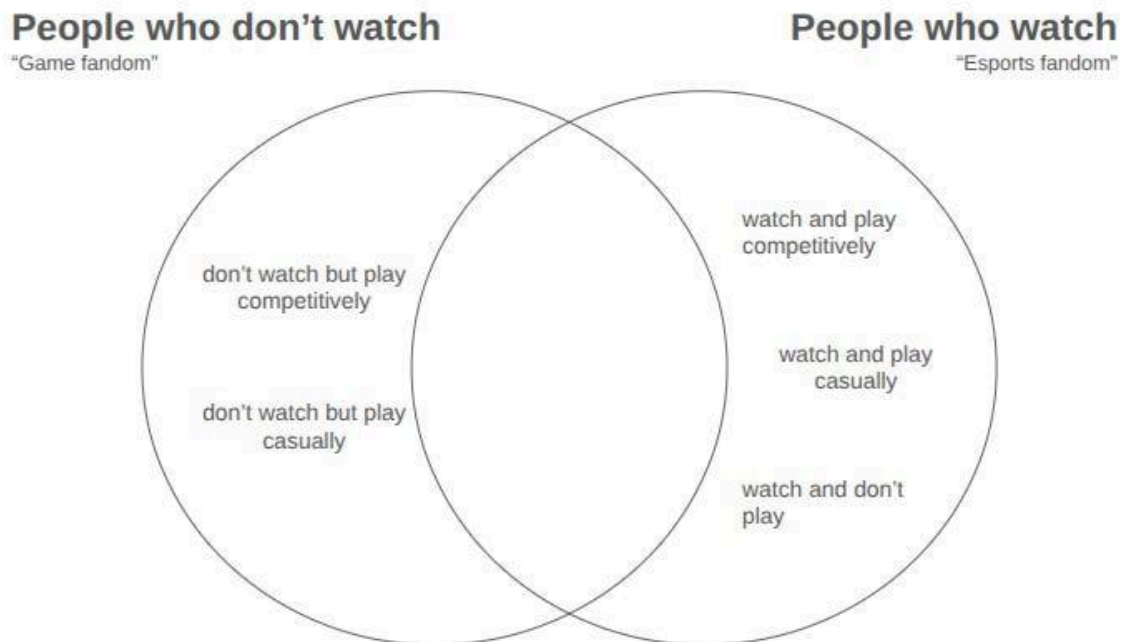
The ground begins to wobble. Do we even know for sure that this niche exists as such? Siege is played predominantly on console, but at the elite level these are connected to PCs. Is it therefore a console esports or a PC esports? Brazil is a fairly easy market to delineate as far as that goes, but what, after all, is a tactical FPS exactly? Couldn't Call Of Duty single-player or co-op campaigns be logged in that genre? If so, why does it feel like it makes sense to exclude Call of Duty single player from the comparative analysis of exclusion within the niche? Is every

new Counter-Strike (1.6, GO, 2) a new esports, or are they all the same? What about every Call Of Duty, or previous Rainbow 6 titles?

Troubling, messy - and this is not the half of it. We've upset the apple cart and questions are starting to tumble out all over the place: What do I even intend to measure here, precisely? If we measure player-base in a region - this is presumably "game" focused. But what if they only play because they've been inspired by the esports? On the other hand, if we measure viewership, well, are they watching the "game" or the "esport"? Another way of asking this is: Even if we could establish these niches, what is competing for attention within them? A *play* experience or a *watch* experience? We are interested in esports - so the temptation is to say "watch". But can we imagine a situation where, for example, the vast majority of players in a market *play* League Of Legends but *watch* DotA 2? If not, what is the functional difference between play and watch here?

Sheesh.

Ok, we take a different run at it: In what ways is analysing "esports" different to analysing "game fandom"? Conventional wisdom holds that game fandom primarily refers to the swathe of players who play a game without a strong competitive motive, and not professionally. The esports fandom, then, is made up of people who *watch* but don't *play*, who *play competitively* and *watch*, but also those who *play casually* and *watch*.



conventional wisdom

But in my personal experience as a lifelong player, friend and colleague of players - casual and competitive play is less a divide between people and more often a - dare I say - daily vibe thing. It depends on the mood of the individual. Sometimes I want to tryhard. Sometimes I want to have a chill game. Sometimes I want to watch. Often, I do more than one of these things at once. The actual Venn diagram of an esports title should look more like this:



a less dumb Venn diagram

The point here is that most people move fluidly - albeit at different rates and intensities - between casual-motivated play, competitive-motivated play, and watch. It is not as easy as a clean split between game fandom and esports. Therefore, when we measure esports, what about that exactly is not *also* measuring game?

At this point in my unravelling, I am beginning to feel like there is something wonky happening when we try to create any meaningful gap between game and esports at all. Indeed, it starts to feel like their indivisibility is hidden in plain sight: Consider that by conventional wisdom's own standards, the relationship between esports and game is symbiotic to the point of total co-dependence - esports are frequently acknowledged as the "tail of the dog" - a metaphor which makes them part of the same *organism*. In many accounts, the entire function of an esports is to generate a "play-watch-play" loop - i.e. to serve as a sort of pallet cleanser for players (people who are already playing!) who will ultimately be inspired to play more once the show is over - or even as the show continues.

This begs the question: What is the analytical value of trying to divide game and esports? What would it look like if we stopped trying to?

And this is how I found myself (cf. below photo), at the question I should have been asking in the first place: What the fuck are we talking about when we talk about esports anyway?



## **we're gonna need some better words**

Ok, let's try to clean this up. First, we get tight on the problems (there are two).

1. The unit of analysis isn't clear. I am not convinced that distinguishing game from esports is either (a) productive/real or (b) possible in terms of tractable analysis.
2. The vectors we're using to contain different esports (or whatever these are) and test them against each other are leaky (tactical-FPS, MOBA, PC, console, even game titles in a series - it's all too porous - where does any of that really end and begin?).

In order to get to a clearer picture here, then, we need a unit of analysis that captures something essential that is often split between the ideas of "game" and "esport" on the one hand, and is cleanly distinguishable from other instances of its case on the other. Then, secondly, we need a way to reliably draw lines around this thing such that we can compare and contrast them, understand their dynamics: how they grow, why they contract, and the conditions under which they may be encouraged to bloom and multiply.

Let's start with the first thing: a unit of analysis.

## **what are we actually analysing?**

Last time, I identified an "esport" as

*"the professional play of video games for cash, broadcast for entertainment."*

There are a few things we uncovered above that are missing here. For one thing, this definition doesn't explicate a requirement for an audience. For another, and perhaps because of the first thing, it cannot accurately capture the necessary components it takes to be a consumer of esports. It is, in fact, a supply-side definition only. It captures what gets produced for consumption; it says nothing about the requirements of consumption itself. Yet, the consumption component is key - without it, we are broadcasting gameplay into a void, which is not a situation anyone is going to pay for for very long. In order to make this definition of esports complete, then, it actually requires that we add demand-side parameters to the definition.

We have to be a little bit careful here, because with good reason I previously left the trajectory of an audience size (that is, growth or stability) as a metric to measure *success level*, rather than *identification*, of an esports. We can stick to this: an esports must have an audience. The size and state of that audience is one predictor of its relative success compared to other esports. That *fact* of an audience at all is enough for definition.

But what else is there here? What else does it take to be a consumer of esports? Pay attention: This is where I am about to make the jump - it will be up to you to determine if I stick the landing.

The above, less dumb Venn diagram highlights that the "watch" component - the element of audience - is actually only part of the picture for the average viewer. For the vast majority of esports consumers, "play" and "watch" are actually part of the same consumption experience overall. It is widely recorded, for instance, that most esports watchers are often playing *at the same time* - called, of course, "second screening". There is also the matter of accessibility. For many titles, visual complexity is so high that tens or hundreds of hours of play are *a predicate for watching at all* (have you ever tried to show DotA2 to a friend who doesn't play games?). It is my assertion that the connection between watch and play is so necessary that it is not useful to try to break them apart at all. It is better to see them as aspects of the *same thing*.

Let's work this up a bit.

What happens when I play video game title for which there is a professional scene? First: I am trying to win. The experience is *competitive*. In the vast majority of cases, I am playing with a team. The experience is therefore also *social*. What happens when I watch professionalised play of that game? First, I am usually rooting for a team - whether that's for national affiliation, team affiliation or player fandom reasons. I want them to win. This is also in that sense *competitive*. What else am I doing? I am posting in or observing Twitch chat, I am checking Twitter to see tweets from Pros, I am celebrating when my favourite player wins, I am on Discord discussing the match with my friends. Watching is *also* in these ways deeply social. I may even be talking about the same things in each case: comparing plays of my own (in the first) and comparing plays of a pro (in the second), for example.

The point here is that whether I am watching or playing, I am participating in a *social-competitive practice and community*. The difference between the two is of emphasis; of degree - not of type.

Ok - now we're getting somewhere real. Let's try on a different definition:

*An esports is the professional play of video games, broadcast for entertainment, where there is an audience participating in a social-competitive community of practice.*

Hm. Better, but for the vast majority of people who participate in the esports (the viewing audience and average players), professional play is a sort of consumption opportunity... it is not their direct experience. This framing still feels too much like it prioritises the professional component. Here's another:

*An esports is any video game that enables social-competitive practice of play.*

Woof. Now we're cooking. But there's something weird here still (watch out, another jump is coming): Is Microsoft Excel a video game? *No*, I hear from the ether. Is the Microsoft Excel World Championships therefore not part of an esports? Is the Geoguessr World Championships, which is originally based on Google Maps? Both have social-competitive communities of practice, so in my book - they are. Esports, that is. So our definition needs another change:

*An esports is a social-competitive practice of play.*

Hm. Sure. But what then is the difference between esports and physical sports? Or, for that matter, one-off evenings playing friendslop competitively with friends? Or Zoom pub quizzes?

*An esports is any persistent, competitive, community practice of play, mediated by software.*

Ding ding ding.

Why is it better that we define esports this way? I put to you a couple of implications:

### **De-centering Video Games invites a sharper understanding of the esports business and broadens the business development conversation in the esports business**

By decentering the Video Game, and putting our focus instead on the human network that is really the heart of the phenomenon, we actually capture more accurately the entity that generates value within this whole conversation: Attention. Attention is a property of the human network, not the video game. The video game is just inert software. In this definition, it is an input - a sort of substrate - and therefore interchangeable with fundamentally different softwares (as the Microsoft Excel example demonstrates).<sup>1</sup>

A key thing I'd like to call out here is that this blows open business development pathways within esports. When we look for monetisation opportunities, we are not looking for Video Games per se. Following release calendars for new multiplayer titles is helpful, but a little myopic. Instead, we should cast a wider net - looking for any substrates that can generate social-competitive communities of play.

## **Focusing on the human network draws our attention to the varied behaviours esports include**

By making the human network itself our unit of analysis, we also allow ourselves to be a little more accommodating of complexity. Networks are emergent - they are constantly being reinforced, adapted and expanded based on the cumulative behaviours of the humans that make them up. They are not one type of behaviour. They are a soup of behaviours, moving and shaking all the time, scaling up and scaling down as more people join and leave the active network moment-to-moment.

In this telling: playing VALORANT is as much a part of esports participation as watching the professional play of VALORANT. I cannot emphasise this enough - we must blow up the distinction between game and esports, it is wrongheaded. VALORANT is a piece of software that enables social-competitive practices of play. These practices include both watching and playing the Video Game (and many other behaviours including verbally communicating with other people, travelling to events, buying and wearing merchandise - the list goes on). Our task is to identify these dimensions of the network and, as industry professionals, our vested interest is to fan their flames.

## **Wheels up (or, shit, I gotta wrap up already)**

Remarkable how quickly I can find I've talked to myself for 2,500 words. Who will read this? Possibly no one. Why am I therefore restraining myself from waffling my way back to the problem (2) - that of how we analyse the dynamics between esports appropriately? Possibly for no reason. Nevertheless, here feels like the sensible place to stop.

I will address problem (2) shortly (much of the material was in an earlier draft of this post). Instead, let me offer an interim conclusion: Esports are best understood as *persistent, competitive, community practices of play, mediated by software*. This is a definition that contains my old definition and then some. It is better than my old definition because it more honestly reflects the human reality of experiencing an esports - something that is more complex than usual discussions allow for.

It is - most importantly - much firmer ground from which to move forward. Which I intend to do in short order. Stay tuned.

## **Postscript**

Actually - I leave you with something of a thought starter. A 2023 Deloitte report called "[The Beginning Of The Immersive Sports Era](#)" surveyed fans of traditional sports and found that, particularly among younger sports fans, an increasing percentage were on social media, using online platforms to bet, watching a second-screen, or otherwise engaged in software-mediated behaviours while watching their favourite teams play. A portion even expressed interest in consuming their preferred sport via VR. This has made me grin. After spending so many years

being asked whether esports are real sports, it seems only fitting to ask: Are there any sports that aren't esports now?